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Author

DiCamillo, Mark

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Institute of Governmental Studies
102 Philosophy Hall, #2370
University of California
Berkeley, CA 94720-2370
Tel: 510-642-1473
Email: igs@berkeley.edu

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Becerra increases lead over Hilton in California's upcoming gubernatorial election

by Mark DiCamillo,
Director, *Berkeley IGS Poll*

Democrat Xavier Becerra has widened his lead over Republican challenger Steve Hilton in California's upcoming election for governor. The latest *Berkeley IGS Poll* finds Becerra receiving 58% support from the state's likely voters, while Hilton is preferred by 33%. This 25-point lead compares to an earlier eighteen-point Becerra advantage (55% to 37%) found by the poll in August.

Preferences for Becerra are driven by his being viewed more positively than negatively by the statewide electorate, while Hilton is not. About half of the state's likely voters (48%) report having a favorable opinion of Becerra, while 40% view him unfavorably. Hilton, on the other hand, is viewed more negatively than positively by a 51% to 35% margin.

Both preferences for governor and opinions of the two gubernatorial candidates correlate closely to the partisan leanings of the electorate, with Becerra holding commanding leads over Hilton among the state's Democrats, while Hilton's support comes largely from his Republican voter base.

Significantly non-partisan voters, who are often thought of as one of the state's swing voting constituencies, are also backing Becerra by a wide 26-point margin.

When voters are asked to choose two issues as their major concerns in this year's statewide election, "reducing the cost of living" is cited most frequently (44%). Other issues frequently cited in this setting include "fighting against Trump administration policies," mentioned by 37%, "ensuring that my party either maintains or wins control of the U.S. Congress," (30%) and "reducing taxes" (24%).

Reducing the cost of living and ensuring that their party controls Congress are cited by large proportions of both Becerra and Hilton supporters. The candidates' supporters differ, however, in their other priorities: Becerra supporters mention fighting Trump administration policies most often (59%), while for Hilton voters it is reducing taxes (62%).

These findings come from the latest *Berkeley IGS Poll* conducted online September 15-20, 2026, in English and Spanish among a stratified random sample of 6,989 registered voters, of whom a weighted subset of 4,512 were considered likely voters in the general election.

Observed IGS co-director Eric Schickler, “These results suggest that Becerra is in a commanding position heading to November. With 2026 shaping up to be a strong Democratic year nationally, the headwinds facing Hilton in Democratic-leaning California are even stronger than usual.”

Support for Becerra is broad-based and has grown across several key subgroups

Partisanship dominates voter preferences in the gubernatorial election, with Democrats favoring Becerra 90% to 3%, while Republicans are supporting Hilton 90% to 4%. However, since Democrats outnumber Republicans by a nearly two to one margin, these preferences tilt the race decidedly to Becerra. In addition, voters not affiliated with either major party also are supporting Becerra by a wide margin.

On a regional basis, Becerra continues to receive his strongest levels of support from voters in the heavily Democratic regions of Los Angeles County and the San Francisco Bay Area. But what’s changed over the past six weeks is that Becerra now has improved his standing with voters across several regions where Hilton had previously been leading. For example, Becerra has now opened up sizable leads over Hilton among likely voters in Orange County and the Inland Empire and has narrowed considerably the large leads that Hilton had previously enjoyed in the San Joaquin Valley and North Coast/Sierras region.

Support for Becerra is extremely broad based across major demographic subgroups of the state’s electorate, as he holds significant leads over Hilton among voters of all ages, both males and females, and across each of the state’s four major racial/ethnic subgroups. Becerra does particularly well among voters ages 18-29, where he leads Hilton 68% to 19%.

The poll detects some shifts in voting preferences among several other demographic subgroups. For example, whereas Becerra led Hilton by just 8 percentage points among male voters six weeks ago, his lead has now more than doubled to 17 points.

Similarly, while Catholic voters were evenly divided in early August, they now back Becerra by 11 points. While Hilton continues to be preferred by double digit margins among voters identifying themselves as Protestant or Christian, Becerra is overwhelmingly preferred by voters with no religious preference or who identify themselves as atheists.

The poll also finds Hilton holding a two-to-one lead among voters who say they will be casting their ballots in person either on or before Election Day. However, Becerra is preferred by the much larger population of voters who say they will be returning their ballot either at a drop box or by mail.

<i>Table 1</i> Comparing voter preferences for governor in mid-September vs. early August <i>(among likely voters in the November general election)</i>						
	Mid-September			Early-August		
	Becerra	Hilton	Undecided	Becerra	Hilton	Undecided
	%	%	%	%	%	%
Total likely voters	58	33	9	55	37	7
<u>Party registration</u>						
Democrats	90	3	8	88	6	6
Republicans	4	90	5	4	91	5
No Party Preference/other	56	30	14	58	30	12
<u>Region</u>						
Los Angeles County	64	26	10	60	31	9
San Diego County	53	35	12	50	39	11
Orange County	51	42	7	45	49	6
Inland Empire	51	40	9	46	48	6
Central Coast	59	34	7	62	33	5
Sacramento/North Valley	53	42	6	50	45	5
San Joaquin Valley	45	49	6	38	57	5
San Francisco Bay Area	68	23	9	69	24	7
North Coast/Sierras	45	48	7	44	53	3
<u>Age</u>						
18-29	68	19	13	69	17	14
30-39	59	29	11	62	30	8
40-49	58	34	8	53	42	5
50-64	53	39	9	52	39	9
65 or older	58	36	7	54	40	6
<u>Gender</u>						
Male	54	37	9	50	42	8
Female	62	30	9	61	33	6
<u>Race/ethnicity</u>						
White non-Hispanic	58	36	6	54	41	5
Latino	58	32	10	57	35	8
Asian/Pacific Islander	57	29	14	57	32	11
Black	70	15	16	66	23	11
<u>Religious preference</u>						
Protestant/ Christian	33	58	9	33	59	8
Catholic	51	40	9	47	47	6
Other religions	64	23	13	61	30	9
Atheist	89	5	6	88	8	5
No preference	72	19	9	68	22	7
<u>Likely method of voting</u>						
By mail	63	27	10	n/a		
Return ballot to drop box	71	21	8			
Return ballot to voting center	52	40	8			
In person on or before 11/3	31	62	7			

In this and succeeding tables the mid-September percentages for subgroups may add to slightly more or less than 100% due to rounding. n/a: Not asked in August poll

Becerra's image rating among voters remains positive, while Hilton's image is underwater

One of the reasons contributing to Becerra's solid preference lead over Hilton is that more likely voters view him positively than negatively, while this is not the case for Hilton. The current poll finds 48% of likely voters offering a favorable opinion of Becerra, while 40% hold an unfavorable view. By contrast, a 51% majority of voters report holding a negative opinion of Hilton while just 35% view him positively.

Most of this is tied to the highly partisan nature of voter perceptions of the two candidates, with Democrats holding Becerra in high regard and viewing Hilton negatively, while the reverse is true among Republican voters. Among non-partisan voters, who are often viewed as swing voting bloc, about equal proportions view Becerra favorably as unfavorably, while Hilton is viewed more negatively than positively by a five to three margin.

Table 2
Trend of image ratings of the candidates for governor
(among likely voters in the November general election)

	Total likely voters		Party registration					
	Sept. 2026 %	Aug. 2026 %	Democrat Sept. %	Aug. %	Republicans Sept. %	Aug. %	No Party Pref/other Sept. %	Aug. %
<u>Xavier Becerra (D)</u>								
<u>Favorable</u> (net)	48	49	<u>76</u>	<u>77</u>	<u>6</u>	<u>7</u>	<u>43</u>	<u>48</u>
Strongly favorable	16	18	29	31	2	3	9	14
Somewhat favorable	32	31	47	46	4	4	34	35
<u>Unfavorable</u> (net)	40	43	<u>14</u>	<u>16</u>	<u>83</u>	<u>84</u>	<u>44</u>	<u>44</u>
Somewhat unfavorable	12	12	10	10	11	11	17	17
Strongly unfavorable	28	31	4	6	72	73	27	27
No opinion	11	8	9	7	11	9	13	8
<u>Steve Hilton (R)</u>								
<u>Favorable</u> (net)	35	39	<u>7</u>	<u>10</u>	<u>87</u>	<u>90</u>	<u>32</u>	<u>31</u>
Strongly favorable	22	26	3	4	62	66	15	17
Somewhat favorable	13	13	5	6	25	24	17	14
<u>Unfavorable</u> (net)	51	50	<u>76</u>	<u>75</u>	<u>7</u>	<u>6</u>	<u>52</u>	<u>59</u>
Somewhat unfavorable	13	11	18	14	4	2	14	16
Strongly unfavorable	38	39	58	61	3	4	38	43
No opinion	13	11	16	15	6	4	15	10

Issues of greatest concern to California voters in the upcoming general election

Voters in the poll were also presented with a list of some of the major issues being talked about in the upcoming general election and asked which one or two were their top concerns.

The issues cited most frequently in this setting are “reducing the cost of living” (44%), followed by “fighting Trump administration policies” (37%), “ensuring that my party maintains or wins control of Congress” (30%), and “reducing taxes” (24%).

Large proportions of voters supporting each of the candidates report concerns about reducing the cost of living and ensuring that their party wins or maintains control of Congress. Yet, the most frequently cited concern among Becerra supporters is fighting Trump administration policies (59%), while reducing taxes is the top-ranking concern of Hilton voters at 62%. By far the issue of greatest concern to undecided voters is reducing the cost of living.

Table 3
Top issues of concern to the state’s voters overall and by voter preferences for governor
(among likely voters in the November general election)

	Total likely voters %	Becerra voters %	Hilton voters %	Undecided voters %
Reducing the cost of living	44	38	50	61
Fighting Trump administration policies	37	59	1	31
Ensuring that my party maintains or wins control of the U.S. Congress	30	34	30	7
Reducing taxes	24	3	62	22
Promotion job creation and economic development	16	10	27	23
Improving health care coverage for those in need	14	20	4	16
Protecting immigrant communities	11	17	1	14
Improving public education	8	7	9	10
Promoting housing development	5	6	3	8

About the Survey

The findings in this report are based on a *Berkeley IGS Poll* completed by the Institute of Governmental Studies (IGS) at the University of California, Berkeley. The poll was conducted online in English and Spanish September 15-20, 2026, among 6,989 registered voters, of whom a weighted subset of 4,512 were considered likely to vote in the state’s upcoming November general election. Funding for the poll was provided in part by the *Los Angeles Times*.

Data collection was completed by distributing email and text message invitations to stratified random samples of the state’s registered voters. Each email or text invited voters to participate in a non-partisan survey conducted by the University and provided a link to the IGS website where the survey questionnaire was housed. Reminders were distributed to non-responding voters and an opt out link was provided for voters not wishing to receive further invitations.

Samples of the state’s registered voters were provided to IGS by Political Data, Inc., a leading supplier of registered voter lists in California and were derived from information contained on the state’s voter registration rolls, which is a public document. The samples were stratified by age and gender to obtain a proper balance of survey respondents. A separate random sample of Spanish-speakers was drawn from the pool of registered voters who requested that their official voting materials be sent to them in Spanish to enable the survey to assess voter opinions among the state’s Spanish-speaking voters.

To protect the anonymity of respondents, the personally identifiable information about voters that was listed on their voting record was purged from the data file and replaced with a unique and anonymous identification number during data processing. Finally, after the completion of data collection, post-stratification weights were applied to the data file to align the overall registered voter sample to population characteristics of registered voters both statewide and within major regions of the state.

The sampling error associated with the survey results is difficult to calculate precisely because of sample stratification and post-stratification weighting. Nevertheless, it is likely that findings from the overall likely voter sample have a sampling error of about +/- 2.0 percentage points at the 95% confidence level.

Questions asked

Which one or two of the following do you consider to be among your top issues in the November general election? *(SEE RELEASE FOR ISSUES LISTED)*

Below are the candidates for Governor in California's November general election. If the election were being held today for whom would you vote for Governor?

Xavier Becerra, Party: Democrat, voting rights attorney

Steve Hilton, Party: Republican, small business owner

Undecided

Regardless of whom you might support for Governor, is your opinion of (Xavier Becerra)/ (Steve Hilton) favorable or unfavorable, or do you not know enough about him to say? *(ORDERING RANDOMIZED)*

About the Institute of Governmental Studies

The Institute of Governmental Studies (IGS) is an interdisciplinary organized research unit that pursues a vigorous program of research, education, publication and public service. A component of the University of California system's flagship Berkeley campus, IGS is the oldest organized research unit in the UC system and the oldest public policy research center in the state. IGS's co-directors are Professor Eric Schickler and Professor G. Cristina Mora.

IGS conducts periodic surveys of public opinion in California on matters of politics and public policy through its *Berkeley IGS Poll*. The poll, which is disseminated widely, seeks to provide a broad measure of contemporary public opinion, and to generate data for subsequent scholarly analysis. Veteran pollster Mark DiCamillo serves as director of the *Berkeley IGS Poll*. For a complete listing of stories issued by the *Berkeley IGS Poll* go to <https://www.igs.berkeley.edu/research/berkeley-igs-poll>.